

The following oral history interview is the result of 1 videorecorded session of an interview with Charlen McNeil by Cynthia Tobar on February 9, 2018 in New York City. This interview is part of the Black Live Matter in Higher Education oral history project. Charlen McNeil has reviewed the transcript and has made minor corrections and emendations. The reader is asked to bear in mind that they/she/he is reading a verbatim transcript of the spoken word, rather than written prose.

Charlen McNeil

[Start of recorded material 00:00:00]

Charlen: [00:00:01] Hello. My name is Charlen McNeil. And I'm a [HP C] student, higher and post-secondary education master's student, second year.

Interviewer: What is your background?

Charlen: [00:00:11] So I grew up in Hoboken, New Jersey. And my mom is my biggest influence. She was a Black Panther when she was growing up. So she started Meals on Wheels and the breakfast for children and just being very involved in that. And then as she got older, she joined the NAACP and that's around when I was born so she was involved in that for all of my life. She pretty much taught me how to be an activist. I didn't really have a choice. So many people were like oh, of course you're about doing what's right. You're Dorothy's daughter. It's fine. And I kind of got inspired by her and just wanted to see what that was really about.

[00:01:09] I also grew up on the children's principles of the Black Panther parties so it was very much ingrained into my upbringing. And as I got older, I grew up in Hoboken Projects and a lot of crime and drugs and all that stuff. So trying to keep myself out of trouble. I thought I wanted to be a lawyer. And I was like oh I'm going to help my friends and help the people around me to be upstanding citizens and also help them get out of jail. It wasn't until I'd seen , at a very young age, I think I might have been 13 or 14 years old when I changed my decision when one of my friends got arrested that was the same age as me. It was for something that they didn't do and I couldn't understand why the system would do that, why would the system put someone away that didn't deserve it. And my mom, being who she was, had also went to jail for something she didn't do. She was in federal prison for three years. And the more I was seeing people that I loved and I cared about being in prisoned, falsely imprisoned, I didn't want to be a lawyer anymore because I didn't want to contribute to such a corrupt being that is the criminal justice system.

[00:02:43] So I was like I'm going to go onto international studies. I want to be the U.N. and be the secretary general of the United Nations. I wanted to study French and work in Africa, but at the same time, there was something always about social justice there. I wanted to do what's right and help others

do what's right and uncover things that are being wrongly done against people. But something was always pulling me back to education because I worked in a daycare for a very long time. Most of my family is in education in some aspect. Although my mom is the only one in her siblings to receive a college degree. And then my grandmother actually went to Bank Street College which is down the street at 66 years old is when she got her degree.

[00:03:45] So education was sprinkled there and social justice was heavily involved. My dad is 25 years older than my mom, but my dad attended the March on Washington and had always talked to me about what's right even though he had passed away when I was four. The things that I have left of him were – I have a video when I was six months and he's holding me, he's like, bring home a man that doesn't wear sneakers and only wears dress shoes and wears suits. I'm like no one dresses like that dad. You're looking at a video like that's not going to work.

[00:04:34] He was the first black man to own a bar in Hoboken, New Jersey and so having that aspect with the Civil Rights Movement and then being the first black man to own a bar. And then my mom being heavily involved in the church, it was like my life was so all over the place that I knew I could do anything and yet I always came back to what my family was all about/

Interviewer: What was your community experience like in regards to education?

Charlen: [00:05:04] My family, weirdly enough, early childhood education, I went to charter schools. I went to Catholic high school. I went to St. Anthony High School in Jersey City. They always wanted the best for us, to make sure that we went to college and stuff. Although my mom, myself, my grandmother and two of my cousins are the only ones who actually went to college. We believe that education is important and we hold onto the fact that everybody should be educated and should have the right to want to be educated but I think a lot of my cousins went to it and it was like college is hard.

[00:05:46] I kind of learned that college isn't for everybody in a sense of education is for everybody, but college, the being might not be for everyone because there are some people that can't sit in the classroom the same way that we can sit in the classroom and learn from Noah or Corbin or Daugherty. There are people that their brain doesn't work that way. But if you give them tools, they are able to work with their hands a lot better. So growing up, I learned that education comes not only from books and from classrooms but from experiences and it's about learning how you learn and what's the best way for you to learn.

[00:06:35] I had a cousin that is great with animals. He should've been a vet, but because of his experiences with the police when he was 13, 14 years old,

having something on your record and going to jail for some around of time, it hurts your financial aid and it hurts the way that people look at you. So when I went to college, he was telling me how proud he was and how much he loves me and I was like you should've went to, you should go too and become a vet. He was like when I was younger if I thought that black people can become doctors, I might have actually tried. That's the thought of the people that I'm around. Once they get in trouble once or once they get told once that you're not gonna be worth it, why even bother? They kind of gave up. But those are the same people that made sure that I never gave up, that even when I wanted to be out in the street and I wanted to not do homework and wanted to be a kid, they were like no, go inside. You can't hang out with us. Not because you're not cool enough, but because you're going to be the one to make it out. You're going to be the one to do better and bring our whole community higher. Which is a lot of pressure to have that weight that no matter what I do or where I go, I will always have Hoboken on my back. But at the same time, it's an honor to know that there are thousands of people that look to me like [bashocka] do it.

Interviewer: What was your personal educational experience growing up in Hoboken?

Charlen: [00:08:12] So I went to Elysian Charter School from first through eighth grade. I was a part of the second class. So kindergarten was in [nargo] class and then I joined those kids in first grade. It was predominantly white school. Even though I like to call it the U.N. because in my class we had one person from almost every background which allowed me to learn from different cultures.

[00:08:40] I remember third grade, one of my best friends at the time, his name was [Sunny] and he's Indian and he said, for show and tell, I have a wife in third grade. I was like what do you mean you have a wife? He was like my dad said that either he picks my wife or he picks my career. So I said he could pick my wife. I was like OK. As little kids, we're like what, you're already married? That's super cool. And then the older we got, the more I watched him grow and grow out of you know what, you can pick my career, I'm going to marry love not for what you want me to do. So kind of watching him go through his journey.

[00:09:26] And then I had another friend named [Eman] and she's Egyptian. She's Egyptian descent but she didn't have any connection to her culture when we were younger. We called her Bitty because her middle name was Elizabeth and she liked that we called her Bitty. But when we got to eighth grade and when we graduated and in ninth grade, tenth grade, she wanted people to call her Eman because she wanted to connect back to her culture and why she was named that and that her name had a purpose.

[00:10:01] So I feel like where I went to school, going to Elysian, I got to not only go through my own development but go watch everyone else go through their cultural development for all of us to end up where we are now and super proud of our history and my birthday is in February. I remember in sixth grade, we watch *Roots* in class, part of it, and for Black History Month and then on my birthday I got all the presents. I got so many presents and so much money because I felt bad for slavery. I got a card that said, "I'm sorry for what my ancestors did to your ancestors." And I think that's the first time I realized I was black. I don't know how I feel about this card.

[00:10:58] We were all on the same level. Oh this is scary what we're watching. Wow, this actually happened. And then for me, it was like do I get mad at the people around me and then they were like let's make sure she's not getting mad at us. It's not our fault. How can we make up for these things? So my education at Elysian made me culturally aware. It made me appreciate different cultures, appreciate different people and the different levels that they're at. It made me appreciate myself and the fact that I did have somewhere to go that I felt comfortable saying what would now be considered outrageous things.

[00:11:50] So I had that there. And then when I graduated from eighth grade, I went to St. Anthony High School which was totally different. It was all black. We had like three white kids in the entire school. It's a basketball high school. Most of our students that played basketball, whether male or female, go to D1 institutions and I think 15 percent of them go into the NBA or the WNBA. So there I learned what it means to be black. And what it meant to be black in Jersey and what does that look like and how do you walk, how do you wear your hair?

[00:12:30] I came into my blackness there I feel. I played a lot of sports. I played basketball, softball, volleyball, track. I played all the way up until my senior year until I broke my leg and then I kind of was like bye guys. But my education there was again, more social. When it comes to being book smart, I go to Columbia so I guess I'm book smart but when it comes to math, I didn't learn math the way that everybody learned math. I learned a lot of it on my own, which is why I feel like I'm behind because both places were very creative. You do you. You express yourself and we'll make edits later. Express yourself and then we'll fix it.

[00:13:28] Writing a paper, don't worry about citing, don't worry about this, don't worry about that. You just get your thoughts down on paper, which is good but when you get to college, now you're in remedial courses. I remember my math teacher in high school said if you play softball, the lowest grade you can get is a B. So I didn't try. I just played that year because I wasn't going to play my senior year. And he was like if you play, the lowest

grade you could get is a B and don't worry about it. And who wouldn't take that, right?

[00:14:06] So my social education was awesome but my academics struggled with math, specifically, just because people kept giving me a pass – this is going to sound really conceited but because I'm an amazing person. Because I am who I am and I can charismatically get out of things if I wanted to. I try not to because that's bad but I can get out of things. They let me go. I got to college and I started at Ramapo College in New Jersey, and when I got there, I was in remedial math and I was in remedial writing. And there's two levels of remedial math and I took both of those. I think I might have just gotten Bs. And then remedial writing, my professor said, "You can do better than this. I could give you this B but I know you could do an A and you're BSing me pretty much. I'm failing you so that somebody can give you some form of consequence because you're not giving me your all and you're not going to make it through college if you don't give me your all. So I'm failing you. You have to take this class next semester."

[00:15:32] At the time, I was livid. I think now I appreciate it because it made me try harder with my writing and not just everybody is going to be OK if I smile at them and walk away. I'm not going to be able to do certain things like that. But again, I didn't get EOF so it allows for students that are under a certain academic level and financial level to get admitted into schools and then they do a six or seven week classes over the summer before school starts to get you to get to college level. College readiness pretty much. I didn't qualify financially but I qualified academically and because it's a government program, they wouldn't let that go. So that's why I started that way.

[00:16:38] I was at Ramapo for a year and a half until they said, hey, this loan that you were eligible for, you're actually not eligible for even though we applied it to your account. So now you owe that money back and you have to pay that money before spring semester starts which was a week from where I was. I was like so what do you want me to do about that? So I called my mom and my mom drove from Hoboken up to Mahwah, which is about 45 minutes. She was like what do you mean you're not gonna let her into school? Do I look like – it was \$12,000 I needed. It was like do I look like a prostitute to you? I know I'm black but do I look like a drug dealer where I could get \$12,000 in a week? You're telling me that and my daughter can't move on campus? You're stifling her education for \$12,000 that you messed up on.

[00:17:33] And they said, well, the only thing we could do is tell her to a community college and build her GPA is what they said, improve her GPA and then she could come back. But that's not the case. That's not how community college and four years work. I didn't know that at the time. So I went from Ramapo, left mid-semester, devastating, sink, depression, anxiety all the other stuff. Started Bergen Community College and ended up getting a

3.0 my first semester and really liking the community college feel. I had changed from the international studies to psychology. I wanted to study why do people commit crimes. So more like criminology. Then I graduated from there and I went to Fairleigh Dickinson University on scholarship because they have an articulation agreement with them that if you graduate, you get 40 percent of your tuition for FDU taken off. And FDU is about a \$50,000 school. So I got that taken off and I graduated from there. And now I'm at TC.

[00:18:56] It's been a journey. It's been a process. It's been like I had a counselor in high school that told me I'll never get into Columbia. Don't bother applying. That's a reach school. And then when I got accepted to TC, I sent her my acceptance letter like what'd you say? Try again. I think throughout my education I always tried to pull people with me. Especially people of color with me. I quickly realized that you can't force anybody to be educated. You can't force anybody to want to be educated. There's a lot of things that I take on, but I realized that I can't take on somebody else's education and what they value.

[00:19:40] That's one of the reasons why I wanted to be in higher ed. Just finding those people that do want this and they don't know the way, they don't have the information or anything like that and giving that to them to move forward. My goal with education based off of mine, is to open a boarding school for at-risk youth as an alternative to prison. So it would be students who went to jail or got sentenced to go to jail from 6th through 12th and have them come to the school instead of their sentence and giving them the – to use Dory words, cultural capital, information that they need to be in order to survive and progress and move forward and be bigger than their crime. That there's more to them than the fact that they stole a candy bar or even that they sold drugs. There's more to that.

[00:20:45] I had people that graduated with me from FDU that sold drugs. I was like you just didn't get caught but you're a businessman now. He's in the business school and learning that if you give people what they need when they need it, they can always modify what they felt that they had to do. I learned through my education that some people sell drugs because they feel like that's what they need to do in order to survive. Not because they want to be a criminal. People do illegal things to pay for education. That's a thing. That's legit. I need to pay for my textbooks so do you want to buy some weed? That's the lines that I know people have went through and they have said and had the experience.

Interviewer: Could you elaborate on your decision to come to Teachers College?

Charlen: [00:21:42] I didn't want to apply to TC because I didn't think I was going to get in because of what was previously told to me. So my girlfriend and I – I identify as bisexual, and my girlfriend and I were sitting on my couch, this

was before we were actually dating, and I was telling her I have to submit my Columbia application today, I have to submit my TC application today and she's like, okay. I'm like I'm too scared to press the button. I don't want to press it. Why bother? I'm just going to waste my aunt's money because my aunt paid for my application because I didn't have the money at the time. So she paid for my application. I had edited my personal statement and I had given it to this editor that my mom knows to edit my personal statement to make sure everything was good. I had everything setup and I could not bring myself to push the button. Her name is Rachel. Rachel said, "Just do it. The worst that they can say is no. All they can say is no. It's okay. All they can say is no." And I'm like nope, I'm not doing it. I'm just going to let the deadline pass. It was 11:00. The deadline closed at midnight. I was like I'm just going to let it go. So she pressed the button for me.

[00:23:15] I technically didn't apply to Columbia. She applied for me. So she pressed the button and it got sent off. I forgot about my application. I went to something to the Mid-Atlantic Placement Conference which helps people graduating apply for positions in residence life at different institutions. So I actually got a job offer at Wagner where Wagner was going to pay 80 percent of my tuition. I was going to go to their higher ed program. Very new. I think I might have been part of the inaugural class. Higher ed program. Had a job, had an apartment. Was going to live in Staten Island. I was totally fine with this and then somebody from TC Admissions called and said you have to make a decision on your application. I said, "What are you talking about?" She was like have you looked at your email. I looked at my email, I didn't have anything. My letter actually got sent to spam. So there's that.

[00:24:18] She helped me log in because I forgot all of my application log in. I no longer cared about this application. I had a job and they were going to pay for most of my tuition and the confetti fell and I looked and it said, "Congratulations. You have been accepted to Teachers College Columbia University in the higher postsecondary education program." I just stopped and I was on the phone. I don't know if I'm allowed to curse. Bleep this out. I was like holy shit. I got into Columbia. And my mom said, "What?" And then the lady started laughing. I was like I'm so sorry. I'm so sorry. I didn't mean – don't take my acceptance letter back because I cursed with you on the phone. She was like, I've heard way worse. Congratulations. You have to make a decision by the end of the week. I was like all right.

[00:25:13] I hung up the phone and I brought my letter to my mom and there's like tears falling and I couldn't speak. And then my mom's crying and we just cried in silence and watched the confetti continue to fall from the letter. And it was just like oh what do I do now? I have a job. I was a week away from signing the contract so both of them had the same deadline. I called Rachel and I called my aunt and I told her; I was like your application money didn't go to waste. I called all my friends, all my mentors. But my question wasn't

oh I got accepted to Columbia, we should go to campus. It was, “Do I actually want to go? Should I go?”

[00:26:10] Is there a purpose of getting – how much is TC? Expensive AF. So what, 50, \$60,000 in debt with loans? Like I don’t have the money to pay for this school. I don’t know if I’m going to qualify for a loan to pay for this school. Is it worth going or is it good enough that I got in? Strangely enough, I called Wagner and I told my supposed to be boss, that I got accepted to Columbia. And she said, congratulations. Email me when you graduate to see if there’s a position open. I hope you enjoy TC. She did not even give me a choice. Not that she fired me. I probably could’ve said to her, “No, I’m choosing to go to Wagner.” But she was like, no, you take this opportunity. You said that this was your dream school. Did you mean that? I’m like, “Yeah, it is my dream school.”

[00:27:18] I visited Columbia when I was in high school. I did a program called People to People, International Studies. And I did a week at Columbia studying international studies and a week at George Washington University studying international studies. We did Model U.N. I was the UAE delegate so I have visited campus and fell in love but it was an Ivy league school and I was a little black girl. I wanted to go here but do black people go to Ivy league schools? As far as I knew, no. So it was – and then when I wanted to apply, somebody told me not to.

[00:27:55] So it was just all of these things were reinforced so is there a point in going to TC even though I know I can get in when I can go and not succeed? Am I actually smart enough to be here? The letter, as beautiful as it was, was more an identity crisis or I really had to evaluate my self-esteem and I say I’m a strong person. And my mom always says stand in your power. And I try to live by that but that letter shook me to my core. Not because I’m really happy but will I get good grades? Will I fail out? Am I going to fail out of a graduate program but I could’ve had somebody pay 80 percent of my previous program?

[00:28:42] And I came and I met with a financial advisor and she was telling me about the loans that I can take out. And I told my mom before went in, if I don’t qualify for a loan, we will not force this. I’m not forcing this institution to go here. I’m not going to suffer and tighten my belt and do any extra work to be here just to say that I went here. I knew that TC could teach me things but I didn’t think that it could teach me anything that I wouldn’t be able to learn somewhere else.

[00:29:21] It has a network if I want to be able to get anywhere else but I didn’t think that it can actually teach me how to be a higher ed professional better than anywhere else. At the time, and I feel like I said that to make it better for me. Not that I believed it but that I wanted to believe that I can get

the same amount of education just in case I wasn't able to come here. Then I did the loan stuff and it tells you right on the spot whether or not you're approved and when it said approved, my heart sank. And then I actually felt like I got into Columbia. I felt like I can be here. I felt like I can pay for it. I just need to work hard now.

[00:30:06] I'm not going to fail out because failing is not something that I do. I don't know how to fail. I wasn't taught that. So it was like I can pay for it. All right. I got in. Yay guys. Let's go back and call everyone else that I actually got in. Let's post it on Instagram and show the confetti. It took a lot to screenshot the confetti falling. That's a talent, and I had it because I tried. It took me about an hour to get it the way I wanted to where the confetti will be there but you will also see TC on it. It took a minute but that was my journey to just getting to the door.

Interviewer: How does your identity effect your experience as a student at TC?

Charlen: [00:31:01] I feel like it's solidified since I've been here. I've known who I want to be and who I try to be and who I am in my head. And I try to outwardly display that. I know when I first got here, I was trying to keep up with everybody and it was like all right, all these people are doing stuff. It's strangely enough how I got involved with Black Lives Matter Higher Ed. Brian had – they had started it. They had had the first meeting already about what they wanted to do. And then I had met Brian, and Brian said, "You'll be really good for this. You should do this." And I, already in my head deemed him my mentor so whatever he said, fine.

[00:31:48] At that point, I was like well, I don't want to let him down and this might just be something that I need to do to fit in here. It's something that I'm passionate about so it works. I believe in this and what Black Lives Matter stands for and then to do it in the field that I love is fantastic. I would tell him and Kat, we were doing our first program, putting our first program together because I joined Black Lives Matters my second month in TC. So this is very much a part of my identity here. And when we started, I told him I didn't feel like I'm doing enough. You and Kat are just so smart. You guys are so intelligent and you write emails better than me. I just don't know how to do those things. I was feeling inadequate to them just because I was asked to put on the first program that we did that was talking about what was going on at MissU and what Black Lives Matter for Higher Ed will actually mean and stand for, what we will be doing with this program. And they were like Cha, you got this. You can do this. I'm like, no, I can't. I cannot do this. I need your help to pull in things. They kind of were like you're fine. You got this.

[00:33:24] And then it turned out to be a good program which is awesome. But my mom comes to the programs and stuff because this is what she is passionate about as well. And I found myself trying to look at her so I can feel

her strength because that's what she just exudes strength. To be able to get through the program but I was very nervous and I was stuttering and all kinds of – I was not confident in myself at that moment because I was like I'm not good enough to talk to you guys about this.

[00:34:00] That was my first two months. It was like can I be here? I feel like I'm a little bit too real for certain people. When I say things, people think that they should be censored and I don't censor myself when it comes to talking about things that I'm very passionate about or things that I feel like I'm knowledgeable about and if we can have a dialogue, let's have a dialogue about it. And my silliness, people will look at me strange and just like you're weird. And then my hair was red and I wear really big earrings and I'm tall and this other stuff. I found myself at one point trying to shrink myself because I was like I stand out too much here. But I didn't feel like it was in a good way. Then I went to the BSN Gala and I brought my girlfriend and she felt the same way when she came that we were on the outside and everybody else was looking in. I said to her, "Let's go have fun. Let's go enjoy ourselves." That was the weekend before my birthday. So I was like this is my birthday weekend. I'm turning 25. Let's do all these other things. It's going to be fine. We're going to be okay. And then from that moment, I had to live that. So people might still look at me weird but I don't notice it. People still might act different or not like what I have to say but I don't notice it the same way that I did the first two months because I was really questioning whether I deserved to be here.

[00:35:58] I work at Columbia Engineering and I would be there and see the math that is on the wall and me and math, we don't talk. So I was like yay, engineering is not where I need to be. Then I would walk across the library and walk past the statue and be like this is my campus. This is going to be my alma mater. My degree is going to say Columbia and yet I feel so small here and so isolated. I was like I don't like this feeling. I'm changing this feeling. I just don't give AF. I just don't care anymore. I just can't.

[00:36:39] And then having Noah and Katie and Anna and Dwayne as professors, people that do not care. They have to be professional to whatever extent but Anna is always in her own little world. And then Katie is this strong person and I'm watched how they don't let the name Columbia overpower them. So once you get past the name of this school, you can do anything. When you stop thinking about oh, I go to an ivy league school and you just think oh I just go to college, it made everything better.

Interviewer: Could you tell us about the people you describe as your support system?

Charlen: [00:37:27] My support system is lit. There's no other way to put it. They're just the most amazing group of people and I have support for all areas of my life. If I needed somebody just to talk to, I have that. If I needed somebody for

educational, I have that. If I need someone – like I want to be a doctoral student, I’ve already thrown off dissertation ideas too. I have all these people and when I feel like I’m sinking or that I’m drowning, I have people that I can go to. And support is everything. My support system is such a blessing. I have mentors from high school, Bergen, FDU – Ramapo too. Ramapo, Bergen, FDU. I have a mentor at every school I go to but then TC, I have all these people that really care about me whereas other people don’t really get that. So I feel like I’m blessed and I’m honored to have these amazing professors and faculty members and staff that actually just care about my life and whether I’m doing well emotionally and everything like that.

Interviewer: Do you believe faculty and students value diversity at Teachers College?

Charlen: [00:39:03] I think our department specifically values diversity. I think that Janice Robinson who works in the diversity office and her staff values diversity. I’d like to believe that President Fuhrman and her media staff values diversity. I do not think that all of TC values diversity though. I do not think that. There are professors that are sensitive to what’s happening in the world and feel like it’s necessary to talk about in your classes. For example, I have friends that are in different psych programs and their professors don’t talk about mass shootings happening on campuses unless it was done by somebody of color. Or talking about police brutality and when – not Treyvon, you can pick any one of the last police brutality murders that’s happening. That their class didn’t talk about it. There professors didn’t care if their students of color were okay because a lot of us were not okay. Or when Trump got elected, no one cared. They taught class like it was another class but that wasn’t the time to do that. That wasn’t the time to just sweep it under the rug and say, all right, it was another election, let’s move forward. It was a time to talk about if you’re talking about school psychology or school counseling and you can be placed into urban neighborhoods where a child is killed by the hands of the police, these counselors need to know how to handle that but yet you’re not talking about it? You’re in a multicultural class but you don’t address the things that’s happening to everyone in the United States.

[00:41:15] You’re not addressing how Trump is affecting people or how Trump is affecting the decline of international students coming into universities. You’re not talking about how schools are scared whether or not their students are going to come back from winter break or going to be allowed into the country but you’re talking about multiculturalism and you’re talking about counseling and you’re talking about psych and you’re talking about how this teacher is supposed to be able to teach all kinds of kids. You don’t learn how to be a teacher for white kids. You don’t learn how to be a teacher for black kids. You learn how to be a teacher for kids. But knowing that you could be anywhere in this mix, you need to be able to cover it. Which is why I feel teachers that haven’t learned multiculturalism or don’t have that kind of competency at all, can’t teach in urban neighborhoods and that’s why

they get overwhelmed and they result to screaming and yelling and suspending students because they're not trying to help. They're teaching the way the way that they were taught to teach. Not teaching the way that kids are taught to learn.

[00:42:30] Because they have that conflict, they end up failing. And TC is not stopping that cycle. There are friends of mine that are saying I want to change my major or I want to transfer because as a black woman, I can't learn this way because this is not reality. This is an ideal teaching situation. You're not teaching for life. You're teaching for theory. So I don't think that TC – and I think it's due to a lot of TC professors are older and they don't enforce diversity completely because it's like well, I'm an ivy league professor. So blah, blah, blah. They don't care. There are some professors, this is definitely not generalization like that that everybody is like that but I think that there are a lot of professors here that just don't care.

Interviewer: How has your work with Black Lives Matter in Higher Education changed the way you engage in activism in your community?

Charlen: [00:43:36] We had an effect on it for – people that come to our events I think gain a knowledge that they didn't know that they didn't know which is really good that they feel like oh let me try to bring this back to what program I'm in because we have people from all programs that come to our events, which is really good. But having an effect on the greater TC community, unfortunately, I don't think that we have in other departments. There are a lot of departments that don't know who we are or what we do. Which is okay because this is our second year. That's not to say that – and we have to make sure that we know as HP C so that we can then spread out to curriculum or [unintelligible 00:44:36] or to somewhere else. To be able to do that, we have to really get our foundation solidified so this is not we're not doing enough kind of thing.

[00:44:55] But I don't think that we've touched the community the way that we want to yet but it's good with people like Brian who was a master's student, graduated and is not a doctoral student and plans to continue to be involved here. Although I do plan on leaving TC, I'm not getting my doctoral degree right away, whether I come back or not, Kat and I are not that far away that we will be able to help. And then with expanding and getting six people that are involved that are first year HP C students and are going to be here for two years, we're ensuring the longevity of the organization that we can get to the place where we're touching the school. We have to host trainings for faculty members and make it a mandatory thing for them to be there. We can do that.

[00:45:46] We can get involved in the community more. TC and greater TC community. So we are on our way to really touching and doing things like this ensures that decades from now, god forbid HP C Black Lives Matter Higher

Ed is not here, someone can look at it and say we want to bring that back. Where are they now so we can – after listening to your stories, we're really compelled to do this again. So yeah. We haven't touched it yet but I think we're going to get there.

Interviewer: What was your vision of activism before becoming involved in Black Lives Matter in Higher Education? How has it changed?

Charlen: [00:46:36] So my vision of activism, even though my mom didn't do a lot of protesting, I figured she didn't do a lot of protesting because she was older, not because she wasn't a protester. But my vision of activism was being out in the streets and the picket signs and taking over buildings, sit-ins, that kind of stuff. And it wasn't until I started this that I was like oh wait, activism is making sure that people are informed. My mom would never really let me go to protests. I really wanted to go to Occupy Wall Street so bad. I wanted to go so bad and she was like no, because if you're going to be a lawyer or you're going to be in the U.N. or you're going to be whatever and they look back at these pictures and that was you there, these white guys aren't going to hire you. So you need to get in, infiltrate from the inside and then outwardly express things. Everybody has to have spies is the way that my mom kind of put it.

[00:47:41] Not everyone is supposed to be on the frontlines. Somebody has to be the lawyer to get them out of jail. Not everybody has to be on the frontline. Somebody has to be the teacher to teach them the way to correctly protest, not in the sense of going with the law. You can't protest with the law. That doesn't make any sense. But to make sure that you're safe. Somebody has to be these things and those people should not be on the front lines because if something happens to them, they can't teach the next person.

[00:48:13] So I identify with the background people, the education and doing Black Lives Matter in Higher Ed and showing people what it's like on an academic level instead of people being like oh those kids are being too loud protesting, let me shut my window. Somebody arrest them. Somebody do this. But being able to sit down and have a conversation and be like this is why they're doing this. Don't you feel like this is wrong? Let me educate you on what happened at MissU. Let me educate you on this. Let me educate you on that. Let's have a dialogue. Tell me why you feel this way? I feel like I'm on that side of activism and I learned that when I got to Black Lives Matter in Higher Ed because I lost the desire to protest.

[00:49:04] I used to want to but then I studied abroad in China for five months and that's when the riots in Baltimore happened and I was there with a bunch of kids from Norwood University which is a military university and they were like why are your people rioting? I'm like I can't answer that. Why is that for me to answer? I don't riot. That's not what I do. That's not who I am. It's like

yeah, but why are they doing it? I am in China. How can I answer that? I'm not there. I didn't even know what happened. So I can't help you there. And after that, I was like I don't want to protest. I don't want people to question me why I'm doing this. I'd rather sit down and tell you why I'm angry. So it started there but it solidified here where I can actually put words to what was happening.

Interviewer: How has that realization influenced your experience as a student and your future as a higher education practitioner?

Charlen: [00:50:12] Yeah. I think that the dialogue part versus the protest part are both have to happen. The dialogue has to happen and the protest/riot has to happen. I'm not sure about the riot part exactly but the protest part definitely needs to happen. It has to be some discourse for somebody to say why is this happening so now we can go back and have a conversation. And I think that part of my development here at TC and in the higher ed courses has let me to not have a filter when it comes to certain things. When it comes to there are a lot of people at TC that are getting here and coming to grips with white privilege. They don't understand. They've never understood and it's because they've never had to understand. They went to all white institutions, all white grammar schools, all white high schools. They never was faced with diversity to say no, you're wrong and that's okay. But somebody has to tell you that you're wrong. And I'm fine with being that person. I'm okay with no holding back speaking about things.

[00:51:29] For instance, there are some students that will say well, people should be able to pay for their own education. If you can't pay for education, you shouldn't go. And my answer to you is do you think that I should be here? Do you think that I can be here? It's like yeah. I am on loans and financial aid. I would not be here if it wasn't for that. So if you think that I deserve to be here and that I can be and I'm holding my weight because I'm getting higher grades than you, if you think that I can be here, then why would you say if I couldn't afford it, I shouldn't be here?

[00:52:13] And then when you say those things and people stop because it's not about some random black person, Spanish person, Asian person, whatever person that they read in the textbook or that they seen out in some PowerPoint at NSPA. It's somebody that's sitting right in front of them that they have drinks with, that they have conversation with, that they feel that they care about on some level. I am that person. So when you wake people up to like oh wow, maybe that's not exactly what I mean. What I mean is that you should be able to pay the loans back or you should be able to do this, you should be able to do that. Yeah, so should you. Where are the jobs? Where are these things that are happening.

[00:53:04] Like I said, I'm okay with that part of my development. Making people aware of their – or somebody said, not here, this was at a conference. Called black and brown people colored. And I was just like [eye roll]. No, I'm not going to do that. I'm not just going to go into my innate primal instincts to beat the crap out of you because that's just what that word does. But why do you say that? That's how his family addressed people of color. And no one has ever said anything wrong to him because he's been around white people all the time that have not corrected him or not felt anything wrong with what he said. But you're not there anymore. So this is why this is wrong. No one says that work anymore. I was like that's not how we operate and he was like, "I'm really sorry. I didn't know." I wasn't like one of those, oh I don't know, get off my back type things. He was red. He was really embarrassed and he was really scared because he didn't know what was happening and a lot of people almost took him out. So I was like wait, why? Let's find out the root of this issue.

Interviewer: How has your with Black Lives Matter in Higher Education changed the way you engage in in activism in your community?

Charlen: [00:54:39] Well, because of Black Lives Matter and because of my family back at home and specifically the NAACP back in Hoboken, I have gotten offered to shadow the current president of the NAACP. His name is Gene Drayton and he's a really old friend of my mom's. He was like when are you going to join the NAACP back here? I'm like if I move back to Jersey City/Hoboken area because Hoboken is super expensive, I'll think about it. So he wants me to be involved. My mom is speaking at the Black History Month Celebration at Hoboken High on the 28th and I was supposed to speak there too but I'm going to be at NSPA so I can't go. Yeah. It's the education part of activism like I was saying before that I tried to give back and nieces and nephews that are getting to the age of college, trying to work with them and finding where they are on their path and how can I best assist them in that way. Just trying to be there and be visual so that people know if they do need me, I can do that. But because I do live in New York, it's difficult. But New York wise, my best friend and I are hosting a Black Panther red carpet event. So everyone can get really dressed up and all this other stuff. We sold out in four days, which is awesome. So we're just celebrating blackness on this day of this marble god coming into the big screens. So we're doing that, celebrating blackness and celebrating black people that are educated as well and the hard work that happens with that.

Interviewer: It's the 50th Anniversary of the Columbia Student Revolt of 1968./ What are your thoughts about student activism continued influence on culture and politics?

Charlen: [00:56:41] The student movement, I believe, are the start of all movements. Civil Rights and everything started with students and college students that

wanted to change Black Lives Matter. Although the women were older, the protest and the people that formerly started Black Lives Matter but the protest and stuff at MissU and everything like that, those are all college students changing their surroundings. Not being okay with just the norm and wanting to be more and wanting better for themselves. So wanting that and fighting for that, it's so important. I think for any change to really happen, I think the students really do have to be on board because we as students can talk in many languages whether it be in academics or being taught in slang, to be able to bring people together. We have that ability. People tend to pay attention to what happens on college campuses more than what happens in just communities I feel. So they're just so important and dyer and the backbone and foundation to any great movement.

Interviewer: How would you characterize the impact of all the work you've done on your own life and your own thinking?

Charlen: [00:58:24] Black Lives Matter in Higher Ed is my professional foundation I would say. It helped me to feel comfortable at TC even though it was a process to get there. It helped me to organize and just taught me about professionalism in general. It's opened so many doors to other people, like, just getting to know President Fuhrman and when I say I do this to help people and they widen their eyes and get really excited and they want to talk to me. So I get to have more dialogue with individuals about what I'm passionate about. I wouldn't be able to talk about my life, like, if I was to write a book on my life, I wouldn't be able to talk about my life without this being a chapter. And I wouldn't be able to talk about my time at TC without this being a giant part of it. So I love this. And I love Kat and Brian and everyone else involved and everybody who supports us and works with us to make this come true and that really believes that Black Lives do matter and that we belong in higher education and that it is the job of all of us to understand that and make sure that other people understand that.

[End of recorded material 00:59:59]